

BARS CODE
Sivasankar in ED custody

Cross, was a foreign entity and had violated the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) when, in 2019, it transferred 10 million UAE dirhams (about Rs 22.5 crore at the current exchange rate) that had been donated by the consulate to the Kerala government for the Life Mission project. This was after the Centre denied Kerala's request that it be allowed to accept funds from foreign governments to rebuild the state after the floods. The ED chargesheet now alleges that Unitac Builders, which was awarded the housing contract, paid some Rs 4.48 crore in bribes to Sivasankar and Swapna to bag the project.

SIVASANKAR'S ARREST IN THE 'LIFE MISSION' CASE HAS ALREADY STALLED A PROJECT WHICH IS CLOSE TO CM PINARAYI'S HEART

Sivasankar had a sterling career till he was arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in the gold smuggling case and jailed for 98 days. The media uproar over his involvement with the 42-year-old Swapna, and the leaking of WhatsApp chats linking them to the state government became a huge source of embarrassment for CM Pinarayi in 2020. But despite a high-voltage campaign by the opposition targeting the CM, Pinarayi led the Left Democratic Front to a consecutive win in the 2021 assembly poll, and that too with a thumping majority.

Now the case has come back to bite the government. "The records and statements suggest that there were irregularities in awarding the projects. We have to ascertain more facts...," a senior ED official told INDIA TODAY. The agency has already grilled U.V. Jose, ex-CEO of the Life Mission project. The chargesheet mentions six people, including Sivasankar.

A senior government official, though, feels the ED is still fishing and may not have much of a case. "The ED's claims are based on social media chats between Swapna and Raveendran, which were leaked to the media. But the chats do not reveal any substantial evidence against him. He has previously given statements to agencies investigating the case on two occasions," says the official.

The CM is aware of the consequences if ED arrests his close aide, Raveendran. As it is, the investigation has stalled progress on the Life Mission project, one that is close to Pinarayi's heart and has given him the maximum mileage as a CM. The question is, will it now seed the beginning of his downfall? ■

RDIGHI



PLAYING HIS HAND
TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee at a rally in Sagardighi, Feb 19

Murshidabad is home to 25 per cent of India's *beedi* workers, and the industry dominates its economy. Sagardighi falls under the Jangipur parliamentary constituency and the TMC Lok Sabha MP there, Khalilur Rahman, owns a *beedi* company too. Sagardighi has 236,000 voters—most local women earn a living by rolling *beedi*, over 90 per cent of the men have migrated elsewhere for work. For 1,000 pieces of *beedi* rolled, the women earn a paltry Rs 178. Despite such poor wages, workers vote for owners as they feel a *beedi* industrialist as an elected representative could solve their problems. Migrant labourers on the electoral rolls are now being urged to return to cast their votes.

To counter Biswas's clout, TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee has talked about raising wages of *beedi* workers to Rs 220-225. The opposition Left is unimpressed. CPI(M) Murshidabad district secretary Jamir Mollah cites the government's earlier announcement of Rs 268 as the minimum wage for *beedi* workers. "Abhishek is actually bringing the wages further down. The TMC-affiliated unions act in tandem with owners to keep wages low," says Mollah.

Meanwhile, with 66.27 per cent of Murshidabad's population being Muslim, the TMC is stoking fears of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) to consolidate the minority votebank, which is undecided in the face of the various corruption scandals, like the alleged teachers' recruitment scam, that have hit the TMC. At a rally in Sagardighi on February 19, Abhishek accused the Congress, Left and BJP of uniting to defeat the TMC. He also displayed a photograph of BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari with Biswas to prove his point. "A vote for Congress is a vote to lotus... it means strengthening the hands of the BJP to implement the NRC," he said.

TMC candidate Debashish Banerjee, a distant cousin of Mamata's, was expelled from the party in 2021 for allegedly supporting a BJP candidate after being denied a ticket. A youth TMC leader, he has made a comeback with Abhishek's blessings. Mamata herself was in favour of Subrata Saha's son, a teacher with a clean image. Saha's supporters are now livid. Though the opposition seems to be united in castigating the TMC, the ruling party is hoping for a split in votes between the Congress-Left combine and BJP. ■